



THE UNIVERSITY OF
SYDNEY

MKTG6015 Group 2

Product Background Report

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Background Information

The name of our company is Söul Candle Australia, which is a newly established, local Sydney brand specialising in stress-relief candles. We primarily target the Australian market, with our main customer base being women aged 25-44. We are committed to offering high-quality, affordable and scented candles that help relieve stress.

This report provides a detailed explanation of how we developed this product from scratch. It begins by introducing our brand's concept and positioning. Then, it analyses the challenges and potential opportunities we face from both micro and macro perspectives, as well as current market trends. Additionally, as a new entrant, we have analysed and compared existing candle brands in the market to better understand our competitors. Furthermore, we have conducted an in-depth investigation into the characteristics and daily consumption habits of our target customers, using these insights to design our product to offer a better experience for customers.

Mission Statement

Söul is a start-up Sydney-based company dedicated to creating personalised stress-relief candles and committed to bringing female customers with a memorable and unique experience.

- Vision

Escaping the face of sociable disguise, lighting and inspiring the deeper soul's true essence, discovering women's resilience and empowering self-acceptance.

- Mission

We strive to provide consumers with personalised candle options and invite you to join the journey of understanding emotional well-being and self-expression. By offering 30 distinct scents and responding to market preferences, Söul will continue to focus on candle design innovation and fragrance design to attract potential customers and meet their evolving needs. A supportive and reassuring community will be built where you can share your experience and connect with people who resonate with you. Söul aims to bring meaningful connections and inner peace to your daily life.

Background Analysis

Micro-environment

- Customer

Women aged 25-44 are the primary consumers of stress-relief candles (WaxMelters.com, n.d.). They not only consider the fundamental functional values of candles but also seek a higher-level value which benefits their emotion (Verghese, 2022). Apart from lighting a candle to decorate the room, they seek a way to find inner peace after a busy day. In addition, their preference for biodegradable candles demonstrates a solid commitment to sustainability (Statista, 2023). Therefore, the stress-relief candle made from natural materials, combining relaxation with sustainability, is the ideal product for them.

- Supplier

The growing popularity of sustainable raw materials like soy wax and beeswax in Australia is due to numerous suppliers prioritising sourcing eco-friendly, organic, ethically harvested, and chemical-free options to meet consumer demand for environmentally responsible products (The Candle Land, 2023). However, the high-quality beeswax wholesale price reached a peak at 24.40 USD in 2024 due to the increased demand for sustainable products (6Wresearch, 2023; Selina Wamucii, 2024; Figure 1). Meanwhile, the import price of raw materials fluctuated wildly due to the instability of the global supply chain during the pandemic. This increased the complexity of management for the companies, prompting them to relocate the production line to the domestic market to reduce risks (Sharma, 2023). Furthermore, candles produced locally could attract more Australian customers because 86% of Australians stated that they prefer to buy Australian-made products (Australian Made, 2023). Therefore, establishing a local production line not only reduces potential risks but also offers companies an opportunity to enhance both sustainability and market appeal.

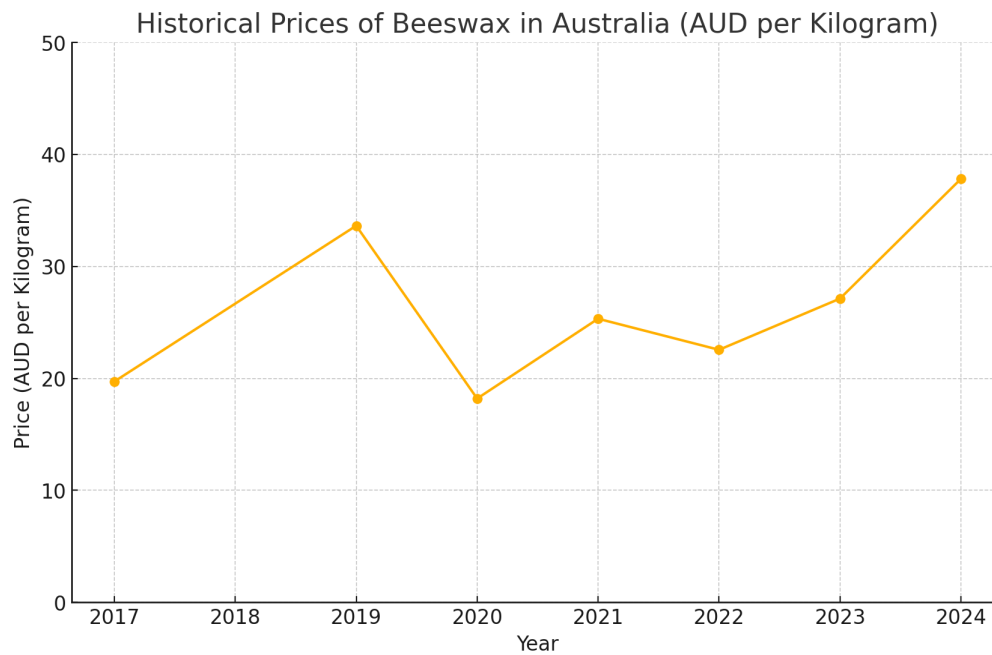


Figure 1 (Historical data of Beeswax price in Australia
(Selina Wamuciiw, 2024; ChatGPT, 2024)) (i.e., 1 USD = 1.55 AUD)

Macro-environment

- Economic

The increasing cost of living in Australia has led consumers to become more cautious regarding discretionary expenditures (McDonald, 2023). This heightened selectivity is likely to have a detrimental effect on sales, as individuals prioritise essential items over non-essential purchases, thereby potentially reducing overall market demand for exclusive products, including candles.

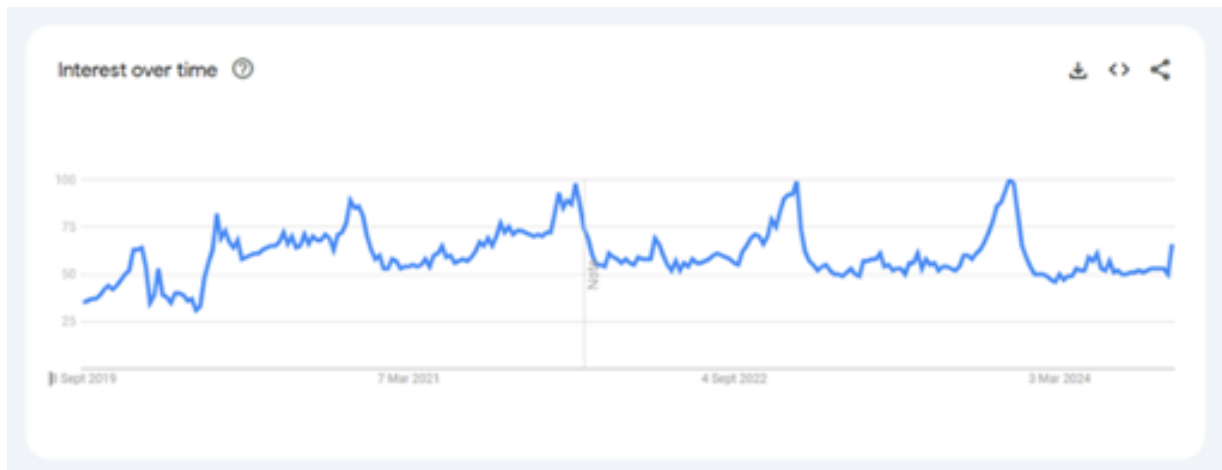
- Social

In Australia, cultural factors contribute to a strong emphasis on holidays such as Christmas, resulting in increased demand for candles during these festive periods (Kuo, 2021). Candles are a readily accessible and cost-effective decorative item, contributing to a calming atmosphere at home (Verghese, 2022). Moreover, candles crafted from eco-friendly materials align with the sustainability values of Australian consumers, particularly resonating with the growing trend among younger generations who prioritise self-care, wellness, and environmental responsibility.

- Current Digital Trends

In Australia, people use social media to engage with new trends, gain information, and connect with others who share similar interests (auDA, 2024). We could build interest-based communities and further expand our audience among those online communities.

Scented candles are popular year-round, with global monthly searches for terms like 'scented candles' nearing 200,000 (Venz, 2024). In Australia, Google's search for 'candle' peaks around Christmas Eve (Figure 2). Thus, we can leverage this trend by launching holiday-themed promotions to boost candle sales.



(Figure 2) Candle search volume on Google in Australia over the past 5 years (Google Trends, 2024)

Competitor Analysis

Brand Comparison				
				
Brand name	Hunter Candle (THE FISH FAT CANDLE)	Diptyque (Cafe)	Jo Malone (English pear & Scented Candle)	Glasshouse (Kyoto in Bloom)
Origin	Australia	France	England	Australia
Brand Image	Hunter Candles embodies an urban and creative spirit, drawing inspiration from Newtown's gritty, industrial aesthetic to create unique olfactory art experiences. The brand appeals to custom (Hunter Candle, 2024).	Diptyque exudes Parisian elegance and refined luxury, known for its classic designs and complex scents that attract customers seeking high-quality sensory experiences (Diptyque, 2024).	Jo Malone embodies understated luxury and elegant simplicity, incorporating classic British style and exquisite craftsmanship (Jo Malone, 2024).	Glasshouse Fragrances is a premium Australian home fragrance brand renowned for its luxurious triple-scented candles and high-quality, long-lasting fragrance experiences (Glasshouse, 2024).
Vision & Mission	• Vision: To elevate people's moods through thoughtfully designed, mood-enhancing candles. • Mission: To offer safe, toxin-free, eco-friendly products while prioritizing sustainability.	• Vision: To spark imagination with high-quality, environmentally responsible products. • Mission: To craft safe, premium candles with sustainable, recyclable materials, meeting strict European standards.	• Vision: To craft personalized scent stories that inspire and elevate spaces. • Mission: To deliver elegant lifestyle experiences through design and custom fragrance services.	• Vision: To lead the global luxury fragrance market. • Mission: To create exceptional fragrances that evoke emotions, enhance life quality, and uphold premium standards.
Price	\$59/300g=\$0.2/g	\$154/300g=\$0.51/g	\$116/200g=\$0.58/g	\$54.95/380g=\$0.15/g
Value	• Functional: Mid in reduce risk and informs • Emotional: Good in therapeutic value, rewards me and wellness	• Functional: Good in quality, variety, connects and sensory appeal • Emotional: High in attractiveness, design, nostalgia and fun	• Functional: Weak in quality and reduce risk • Emotional: Low in attractiveness and reduce anxiety	• Functional: Good in variety, sensory appeal and quality • Emotional: High in nostalgia, reduce anxiety and entertainment
Design	• Have no lid • Premium colored glassware (dark brown or black) • Use instructions	• Have no lid • Scents correspond to transparent glass patterns(eg. cafe) • Use instructions	• Have no lid • Three-wick candles and single-wick candles • Use instructions	• Have lid • Fragrance concentration table • Each fragrance has its own unique fragrance description on the packaging
Reviews	Cannot get enough of it between my partner and I we have purchased 5 so far we cant bare the thought of night having it in our lounge transforming our space with each light. Lovely but not very scented even after burning for a few hours.	The scent is to die for, it lasts forever plus you can reuse the glass jar to store makeup brushes etc which looks so cute! I actually find the memories of the beautiful smells they have flowing through the air on luxury.	Many comments saying air bubbles in the candle, won't buy it again. Unfortunately the aroma which was very little, did not live up to my expectations.	Have not been able to find any candle as good as the Kyoto since its limited edition release. My favourite scents together, makes for such a relaxing atmosphere. I am over the moon to see it back on the online store. Thank you! and please don't ever discontinue this product. I need it in my life forever.

(Table 1) Brand competitors analysis table

The functional value of candles is an essential factor influencing consumer behaviour. According to The Elements of Value Pyramid, candles meet people's fundamental values by enhancing the sense of atmosphere, organising space, and improving the quality of the environment (Hanphitakphong & Poomsalood, 2024). For example, Hunter and Jo Malone create an elegant atmosphere in customers' spaces by offering candles with premium packaging and a wide variety of scents. However, according to Hunter Candle reviews (see Table 1), users point out the issue of insufficient fragrance duration, which suggests Söul needs to ensure that the candle can continue to emit a strong fragrance after burning and can effectively fill the entire space, such as using two wicks. As noted in Jo Malone's review, the presence of air bubbles in the candles affects the overall experience, emphasising the importance of Söul ensuring quality control to avoid similar problems in the future. In addition,

multifunctional candle containers like those provided by Diptyque not only enhance practicality, but also allow users to reuse stylish containers to store items such as makeup brushes. Taking advantage of this trend, Söul can design candle containers that are both environmentally friendly and visually attractive, and can be perceived as an added value.

The emotional value of candles plays a vital role in shaping consumer preferences. The idea behind aromatherapy is that certain scents can positively influence the brain and mood (How Scented Candles Reduce Anxiety and Stress, 2023). Besides, according to (Singh ,2023), lavender and eucalyptus have a calming effect, reducing anxiety and promoting relaxation. The emotional connection often drives customer loyalty, as reflected in Glasshouse reviews, where users express a strong emotional attachment to limited-edition products, highlighting the importance of meticulous craft and thoughtful designs. For Söul, strengthening the emotional value of its candles can be achieved by regularly launching limited-edition collections with aesthetically pleasing designs. It can also attract and retain loyal customers, fostering a more profound connection with Söul.

In addition to direct competitors, alternative products such as essential oil diffusers and candle warmers also influence consumer choices. Despite being famous for creating a relaxing atmosphere, essential oil diffusers can be expensive to maintain (costing \$20 per 10ml of essential oil) due to the need to change essential oils frequently (ECO. Modern Essentials, 2024). It provides an opportunity for Söul to emphasise the convenience and low maintenance costs of candles, which can appeal to consumers who prefer a simpler lifestyle. A candle warmer is another flameless alternative, but it requires frequent bulb replacement, which adversely affects the user's experience (Candle Warmers Australia, 2024). Although candle warmers improve safety by eliminating open flames, Söul can emphasise the safety of its products by incorporating safety features into its candles, such as fireproof wicks or automatic extinguishers. These innovations will allow Söul to provide a more secure user experience while maintaining the classic candle ambience, effectively satisfying the needs of consumers who seek both an enjoyable and safe environment.

Target Market

Target market: Australian working women and housewives aged 25-44 who experience high stress in their daily and working lives.

Target market justification

The true self is always disguised by individuals engaging in daily-life interactions (Gramigna, 2022). When individuals attempt to conceal their emotions in an effort to appear "strong" or "professional," it tends to exacerbate the situation (Northrup, 2020). These situations are more likely to cause negative mental health issues. Stress is a prevalent mental health issue, with 59% of Australians experiencing personal stress in the past 12 months, especially among women (74%) who report higher stress than men (57%) (Hanifie, 2024). A variety of effective and practical strategies exist for reducing stress, including participating in physical activities and employing aromatherapy with soothing scents. For instance, candles are often used to create a cosy atmosphere and are associated with stress reduction and relaxation for women in the workplace and stay-at-home mothers (Bond University, 2023).

Over 95% of candle market purchasers are women (WaxMelters.com, n.d.), with those aged 25-44 leading group who earn between AUD\$500 and AUD\$1,999 per week (Female Salary in Australia - Average Salary, n.d.). Based on these criteria, Söul Candle Australia will offer women aged 25-44 with stable financial standing who experience daily pressures a sensory journey of emotional discovery and stress relief, leading to a more fulfilling experience.

The Brand

- Brand concept

Söul Candle Australia – Söul Candle will offer a product to support these women. Providing the scents of Rosé, Woody and Eucalyptus smell journey of releasing your "Söul", through our candle experience, fully release the stress and embrace every part of yourself. For instance, lighting the Woody scent candle, close your eyes and take three deep breaths to enjoy your self-discovery moment which can release the tension after work. We believe your taste and individuality are both impressive and meaningful. Söul's unique scents and tastes reflect loved memories and fully accept your true self regardless.

- Brand LOGO



(Figure 3) Brand Logo image

- Top 3 Scented candle designs/features product

- Rosé Scented Candle: Capturing the essence of romance and inner serenity, this candle features hints of rose petals and peonies to create a soothing atmosphere. Perfect for a relaxing moment and reconnecting with peace and belief, its elegant, premium-quality design enhances personal moments and beautifully decorates your space.
- Woody-Scented Candle: Escape the noisy city and immerse yourself in a blend of warm wood notes and serene tranquillity. Close your eyes, relax on a log chair, and enjoy the peaceful embrace of nature. This scented candle is ideal for those seeking a natural forest ambience to reduce stress.
- Eucalyptus + Mint Scented Candle: A top note of Eucalyptus mellow middle

layer with mint, and a rich majestic cedar and sunlit amber base, transport you into the forest and enjoy every moment in your life. This scented candle is perfect for individuals who love hiking or outdoor activities and could enjoy a refreshing and recharging moment.



(Figure 4) candle product

- Ingredients: Söul candles are made from natural, eco-friendly soy and beeswax to enhance environmental sustainability goals. The two wooden wicks are lead-free and designed for a slow burn. Each fragrance is selected from natural, organic leaves or essential oils, ensuring safe and long-term commitment products.
- Burning hours: 300 grams with 55-65 burning hours per candle
- Candle size: 300g candle and glass jar sized 85mm (D) x 98mm (H)
- Packaging design: The candle will be a glass jar, and the package is designed with dark green biodegradable paper and an eco-friendly box with a logo printed and sized 12cm(L) x 12cm(W) x 14cm(H), the colour represents a calm, relaxed, natural environment. Recyclable materials and minimum packaging can achieve environmental sustainability goals in the long term.
- Relaxation packaging: offer a three-set gift package with an elegant bow tie for your special.



(Figure 5) packaging design

- Service: 24-hour online robot customer service will be provided across the website and social media platforms, Offering return and feedback services and comprehensive FAQ information to manage common questions.
- Recycle Used Candle Jars service: Return burned-up candle jars and earn membership points as a commitment to environmental sustainability together.
- Shipping information: 3 to 5 working day shipping service
- Technology: Customise your candle present with RFID (radio frequency identification) technology to demonstrate personalised videos or messages linked to websites, videos, and music, creating a memorable experience for your meaningful friends and families.
- Pricing Strategy

The pricing strategy is designed to reflect the premium quality and nature-based focus of the product. Based on competitive analysis, which identifies a typical price range of 50 to 200 AUD for candles, the price for a single 300g candle is set at 99 AUD (see Table 1). A more value-driven option is offered through the "Relaxation Pack", a 3-candle set with mixed scents, priced at 290 AUD. To incentivise immediate purchases, first-time visitors who register with their phone number and email will become standard members and receive a limited-time 10% discount that is valid for

15 minutes. Moreover, members qualify for free shipping, which waives the 10 AUD delivery charge.

A variety of payment methods are accepted, including Apple Pay, Samsung Pay, credit cards (VISA, Mastercard, American Express), Afterpay, PayPal, Google Pay, UnionPay, and Shop Pay, ensuring a seamless and flexible checkout experience for all customers.

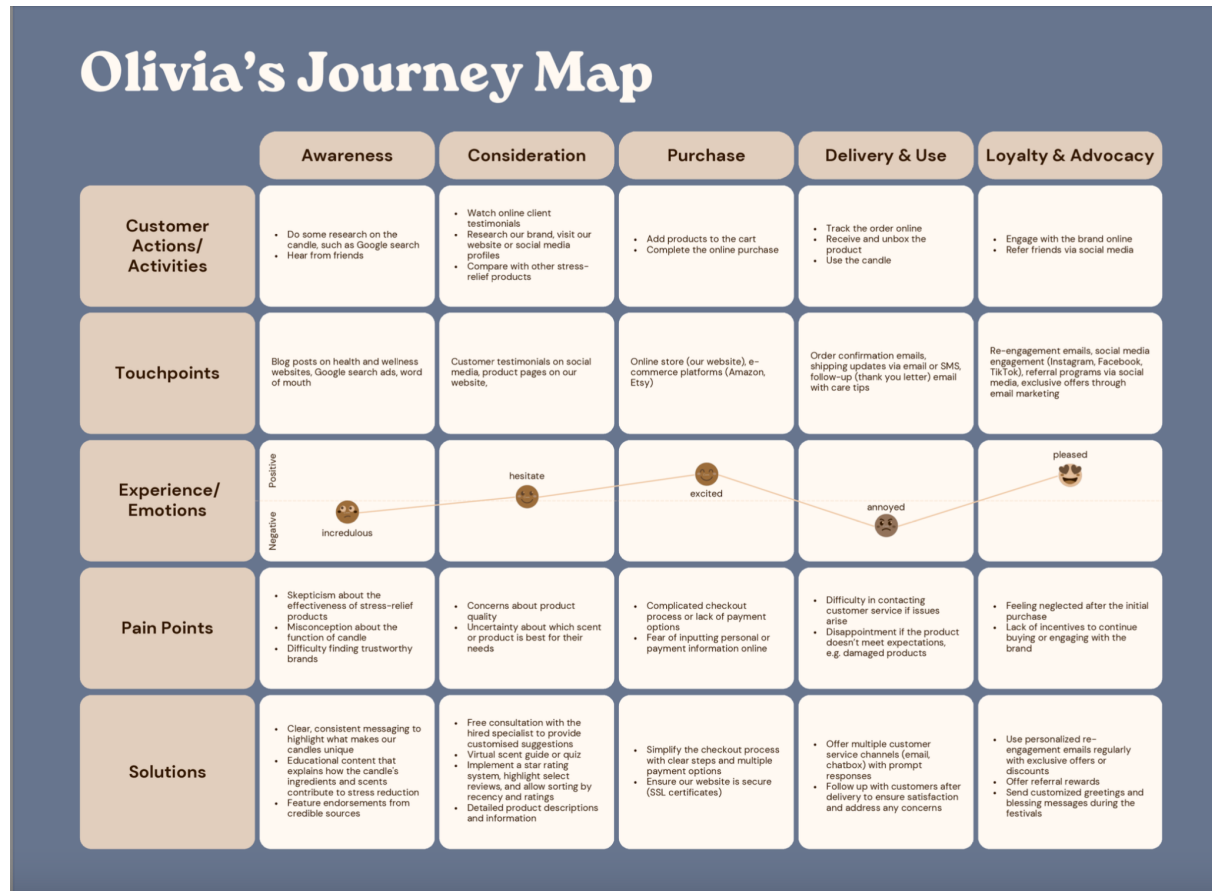
Customer Personas

Name	Olivia	Occupation	University professor	Age	35
Gender	Female	Location	Sydney	Income	\$80,000 AUD per year
Life-cycle stage	Married No kid	Personality	Introvert, Christian, analytical, logical, humble, friendly	Brand Loyalty	World Vision Au, Wear Pact, Mercedes Benz, Apple
Hobbies	- Participant Christian every Lord's day - Shopping with her family and friends - Writing and reading (research paper and fiction) - Playing the piano and Listening to music - Studying history or philosophy				
Top Reason they choose Söul (Motivations)	- Depression high stress in maintaining social relationships (e.g., Christian group and teaching group) - Work-life balance issue - Mental anxiety problem				

Name	Mia	Occupation	Marketing specialist	Age	26
Gender	Female	Location	Melbourne	Income	\$65,000 AUD per year
Life-cycle stage	Single	Personality	Enthusiastic, honest, adventurous, cheerful, confident, extrovert	Brand Loyalty	The body shop, Apple, Patagonia, Mecca
Hobbies	- Digital content creation: Blogging and vlogging her daily life on Tiktok and Instagram - Travelling to different countries - Volunteering in Wild Animal Rescue Station - Join Running, Hiking and Kayaking groups during the weekend				
Top Reason they choose Söul (Motivations)	- High stress in the competitive working environment - Burn-out of content creativity ideas - High pressure on financial management - Worry about other individuals' opinions				

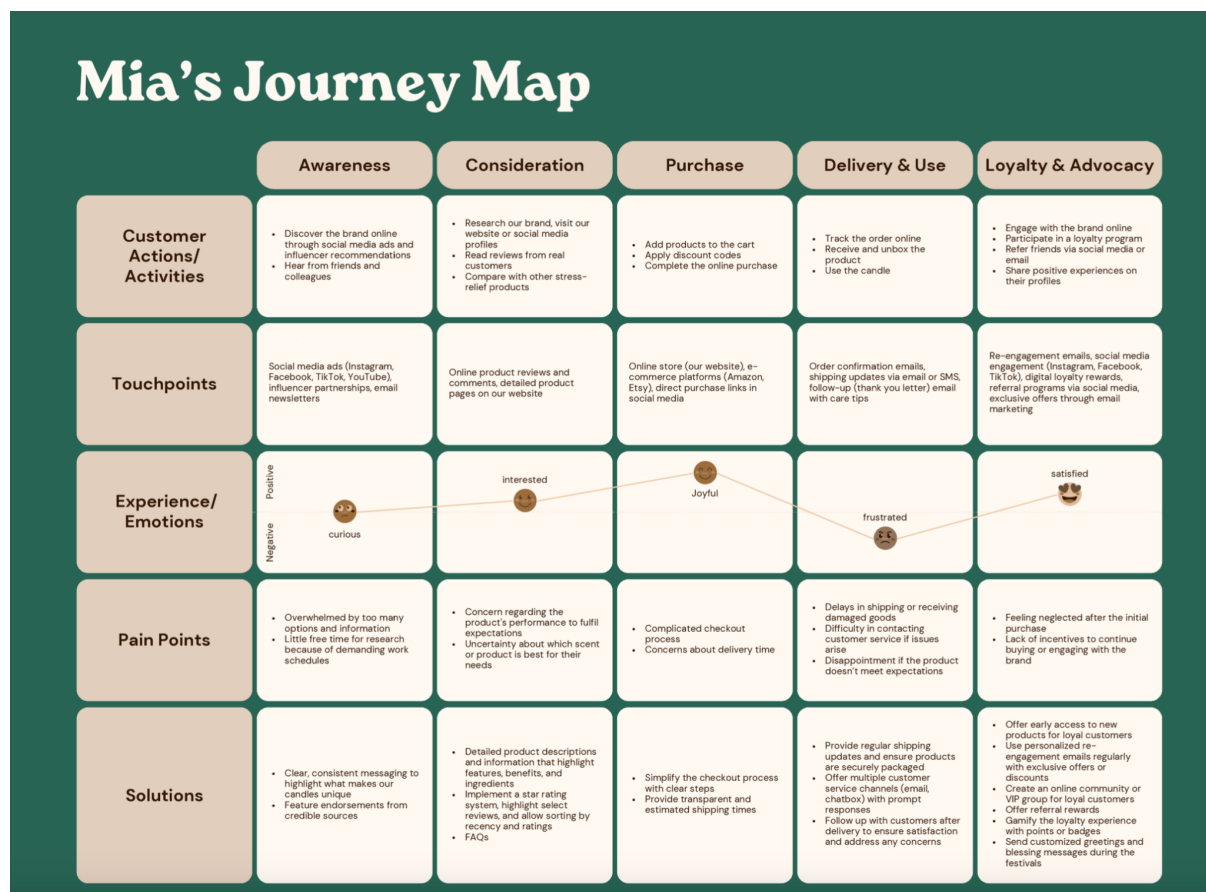
Name	Emma	Occupation	Full-time mom	Age	34
Gender	Female	Location	Sydney	Income	Comes from Husband
Life-cycle stage	Married with two children (8 years old and 4 years old)	Personality	Caring, dependent, hardworking, gracious, moody, warm-hearted	Brand Loyalty	IKEA, TikTok, Nature Baby, lululemon
Hobbies	- Take Yoga and meditation classes during her free time - Coffee brewing or tasting and Learning a musical theory - Decorate her house and yard				
Top Reason they choose Söul (Motivations)	- Busy with a mountain of household duties - Stuck in her dull routines of life - Social isolation, such as a small social network and infrequent social activities				

Customer Journey



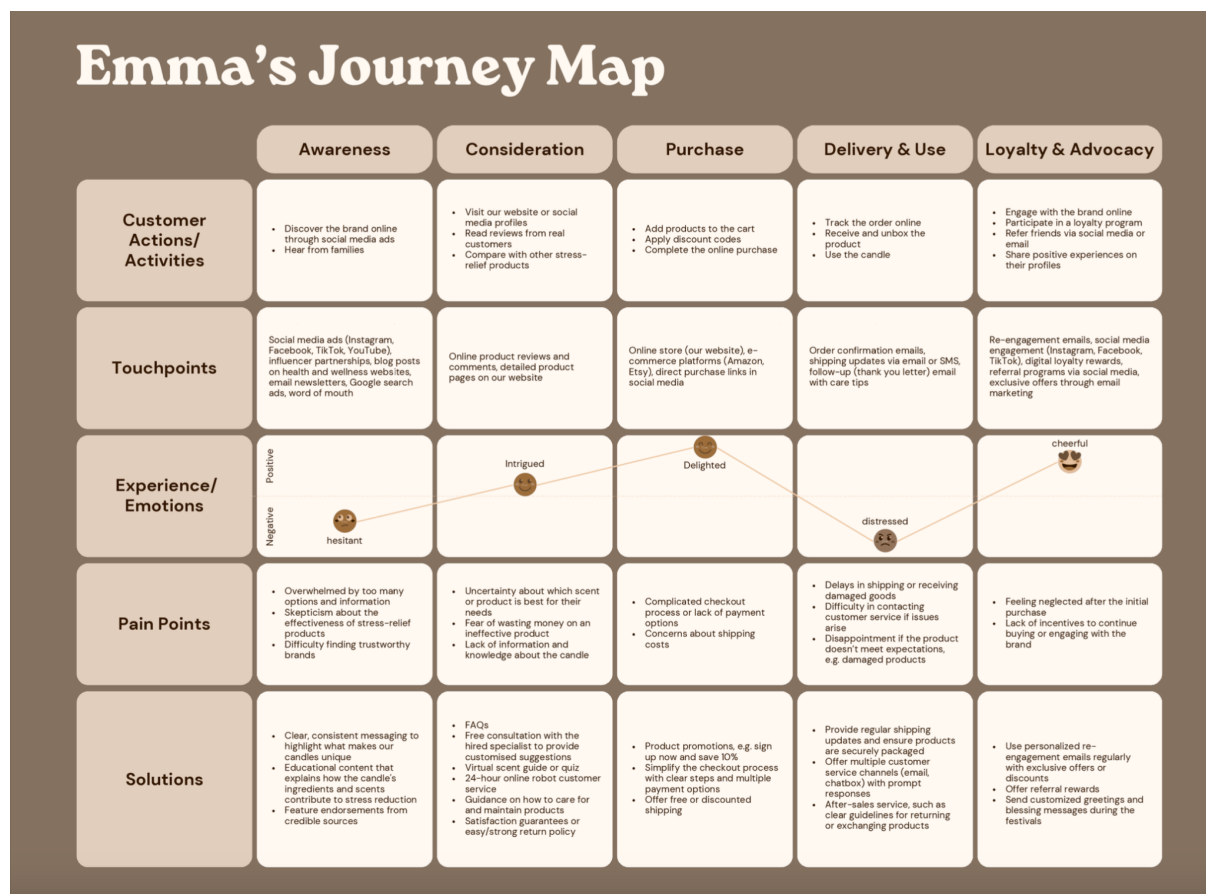
In the awareness stage, successful link-building is crucial for improving online visibility, credibility and search engine rankings (Doshi, 2021). By securing placements for ads and blog posts of Söul on authoritative wellness and health Australian websites, the brand's Google ranking and web authority can be considerably enhanced.

To address customer pain points related to the concern about product effectiveness—an inherent cost-benefit analysis performed during the consideration stage—leveraging online testimonials is imperative (Lakho et al., 2023). For instance, the testimonials featuring unboxing experiences from referred customers showcase the tangible aspects of the product (Wided Batat, 2021). These testimonials, especially in visual formats, can offer insights into the overall experience, thereby enhancing trust in Söul and aiding in the decision-making process for uncertain customers.



At the loyalty and advocacy stage, an engaged online community or VIP group, such as on Facebook or Instagram, cultivates a sense of belonging and deepens connections with the brand (Huang et al., 2022). To be more specific, the social community zone incorporates discussion forums, social networking sites (SNS), message boards, and many other multimedia-sharing channels (Tuten, 2023). Consequently, it can serve as an inspirational incubator for Söul and foster brand affinity.

According to Silva et al. (2023), the gamified loyalty program, which integrates innovative game design elements into a traditional loyalty framework, enriches the customer experience by making interactions more appealing. Through the incorporation of gamified elements, CRM systems leverage psychological theories such as the sunk cost fallacy, which fosters customer commitment over the long term. (Garaialde et al., 2021). By implementing this approach across the owned media, Söul's loyalty program can incentivise participation through a tiered points system.



To resolve the issue of lack of knowledge about candles, Söul may adopt various strategies. The product can be supplied with comprehensive instruction manuals that detail usage and safety guidelines, along with guidance on lighting techniques, burn time recommendations, wick trimming, and proper storage methods. Additionally, engaging online tutorials can be created to demonstrate these techniques visually. The vivid online tutorials captivate consumers' attention to substantive information, enhancing their perceived learning (Steils, 2023). Furthermore, leveraging social media platforms to disseminate care tips can significantly enhance customer understanding and confidence in maintaining the product.

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Acknowledgement

I acknowledge the use of ChatGPT (<https://chat.openai.com/>) to assist in generating prompts for image creation of our products. On [17 September,2024], I used ChatGPT to craft detailed descriptions to input into DALL-E for visualising our candle products.

I acknowledge the use of ChatGPT (<https://chat.openai.com/>) to assist in generating data for figure creation. On [19 September 2024], I used ChatGPT to craft figures, which helped visualize our History prices of beeswax in Australia."